

**Mansfield Municipal Electric Department
Minutes of Light Commissioners Meeting
March 17, 2025**

Present: Chairman Brendan Roche, Clerk Maureen Doherty, Commissioner Diana Bren, Commissioner Walter Wilk, General Manager Joe Sollecito, Line Supervisor Ralph Bellavance

- 1) **Open Meeting – Call to Order & Pledge of Allegiance.** The meeting was held at the Mansfield Town Hall Room 3AB and called to order at 6:05 PM followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.
- 2) **Review and consideration to approve Board Minutes**
 - a) February 24, 2025 meeting
Motion to approve Board Minutes. (Doherty/Bren) Passes 4/0.
- 3) **General Manager's Report**
 - a) **Cable pulling trailer** – Manager Sollecito stated that this acquisition would be listed on the FY26 Capital Budget, but that there is an imminent need for it so would like to order one right away.
 - Line Supervisor Ralph Bellavance explained that currently underground wire was pulled with a digger truck with a bed winch that has to be rigged to pull the wire. This can sometimes damage the wire. The cable puller would make the job faster, easier and most importantly safer. Additionally, it has an air compressor that blows the lead string through to then pull the cable. It is more maneuverable making it easier to move where it will work best.
 - Manager Sollecito stated that receiving this equipment sooner would allow the crew to install the new cable that was purchased for the Jewell St project by September 1 and have it ready for winter.
 - Commissioner Bren asked about the price, to which Manager Sollecito replied that it is \$213,000, plus \$4600 in shipping for a total of \$218,000.**Motion to approve the FY26 Capital Purchase request for the Cable Puller trailer in an amount of approximately \$218,000. (Doherty/Wilk) Passes 4/0**
 - b) **DPU Report** – Manager Sollecito explained that this is a report required of all municipal utilities. The items in the report are in line with years past, with changes to the actual sales numbers.
Motion to approve Mansfield Electric's Department of Public Utilities report as submitted. (Doherty/Bren) Passes 4/0
 - c) **Letter in support of Public Power** – Manager Sollecito gave a recap of the initiatives that various state agencies are trying to impose upon municipalities with public power. He reiterated that absent congressional review, those agencies do not have any authority over municipal light plants (MLP's). Local boards have the only say regarding the operations of their MLP. As president of MEAM, Manager Sollecito has asked the general managers of all the other light plants to draft a letter for their commissions to sign stating that MLP's are subject only to local control.

State Representative Michael Chaisson was present to discuss the issue from a legislative perspective. Manager Sollecito explained that Mansfield Electric's rates are two and a half times cheaper than surrounding communities. Representative Chaisson noted that this does not seem to be a good time to push these initiatives as people are already hurting financially and these would increase costs. He expressed that Mansfield knows Mansfield best and that he gives his full support at the state level to not have this happen and keep control at the local level. Clerk Doherty asked him if our state delegation could also draft a letter in support of MLP's and he replied that he would work with the delegation to do that. Chairman Roche then read the letter.

Motion to accept the draft letter from the Light Commissioners in support of Public Power. (Doherty/Bren)

- Chairman Roche stated that he is in favor of keeping local control of Public Power. He noted that Mansfield Electric has done a very good job working on green initiatives that have been set. Much of what has already been accomplished is on the path of these state level initiatives. He noted that Mansfield has already reached some goals set for 2040, meaning we are 15 years ahead of schedule.

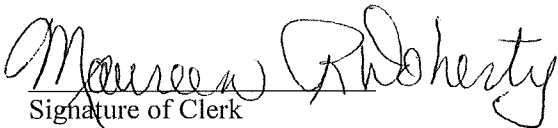
- Clerk Doherty asked Representative Chaisson if electric department vehicles could be considered emergency apparatus so that there would be the same consideration as police and fire. Rep Chaisson said he would look into that since these are vehicles that do respond to emergencies. Manager Sollecito noted that it would be difficult to make exceptions like this since MA follows the CA emissions standards.
- Commissioner Bren also expressed support, noting that Mansfield does not fit nicely into these other regulations and they are actually a detriment to the Town of Mansfield.
- Manager Sollecito also noted that it does not seem as if DOER is using common sense. As they are trying to electrify everything and move away from gas, coal, and oil, it would make sense to keep costs of electricity lower. But these initiatives would drive up costs, making them counter intuitive. Additionally, programs like these work better starting from the local level, rather than coming from the top down.

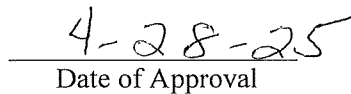
Vote Passes 4/0

- 4) **Citizens Questions & Comments – None**
- 5) **Commissioners Questions & Comments - None**
- 6) **Any items not anticipated by the Chair 48 hours prior to this meeting – None**
- 7) **Vote to enter into Executive Session for the following reasons and NOT return to open session**
 - a) Review and consideration to approve minutes of February 24, 2025 Executive Session where Exemption 3 was declared.
 - b) Pursuant to M.G.L. Ch. 164, Section 47D and M.G.L. Ch. 30, Section 21, Exemption 3, to discuss strategy with respect to collective bargaining (IBEW Local 104 Financial Assistants and Professional units and AFSCM Local 1702) if an open meeting may have a detrimental effect on the bargaining position of the public body and the chair so declares.

**Motion (Doherty/Bren) Roll Call Vote: Doherty-Yes, Wilk-Yes, Bren-Yes, Roche-Yes. Passes 4/0.
Entered into Executive Session at 6:40 PM.**

Respectfully submitted: Katherine Duggan


Signature of Clerk


Date of Approval